eminent domain powers). The combination of small landholdings and weak property rights has discouraged long-term investment by farmers in their land. As a result, Indian farming is hopelessly inefficient and uneconomical. The children of farmers want to opt out. Who are we to stop them? Rural India needs reforms and investment, not subsidies.

Meanwhile, urban India needs to prepare for large-scale migration: large cities will grow larger, small towns will grow big and brand new cities will be built. In some ways, India is merely witnessing what all developed countries have experienced at some stage of their evolution. Development is ultimately about shifting people from subsistence farming to other activities; urbanization is merely the spatial manifestation of this process. For instance, England's urbanization level jumped from 20 per cent in 1800 to 62 per cent in 1890.[23] More recently we have seen how China's urban population has jumped from 12 per cent in 1950 to over 50 per cent by 2012. My guesstimate is that urban India will have to absorb some 300–350 million people over the next three decades. This will be one of biggest human events of the twenty-first century.

The explosive growth of cities like Gurgaon shows that India's rapidly expanding economy may well be able to generate enough jobs. The real problem is to match hundreds of millions of migrants to jobs, housing, and amenities while maintaining overall social cohesion. Slotting so many individuals into the urban fabric according to their respective skills and financial abilities is a colossal task. China used draconian social control systems to manage the process over the last two decades. In most other countries, slums played this role. Even in China, 'urban villages' have been an integral part of the migration process.

Most people tend to be overwhelmed by the poor living conditions that prevail in Indian slums. The usual reaction is to treat this as a housing problem. Over the decades, we have seen many well-meaning slum re-development projects that have attempted to resettle slum-dwellers into purpose-built housing blocks (often on the outskirts of the city). Yet, almost all these efforts have failed. More often than not, the former slum-dwellers sell, rent out or abandon the new housing blocks and move back into a